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Ben held several part-time jobs while he was growing up but rarely stayed at any for longer than a few weeks. Like his father, he believed that the money he made was his to spend as he desired. When he was in the twelfth grade, his father bought him a nice car, and his mother blew up about it because she hadn't been consulted.

When Ben started college, he was encouraged to apply for student aid and government loans. He completed two years of college while living at home but never really decided on a field of study. He took a summer job as an equipment operator with a local power district and received an offer to stay on permanently, which he accepted, rather than finishing his college degree.

He and Naomi dated for nearly a year after they met in college. When Ben took his permanent job, he asked Naomi to marry him, with the understanding that she would finish college and go into advertising and marketing.

Neither Ben nor Naomi received any detailed instructions from their parents about marriage. It was assumed that the pastor of Naomi's church would provide the counseling they needed. Indeed, the pastor did require several sessions in which they discussed sex, communication, and spiritual values. Once he asked Ben if he would be able to support a family, to which Ben replied, "Yes, sir, I make a good living at the Evanston Power District. We'll be all right."

The pastor never pursued the subject further. So having completed what they thought were the requirements for marriage, Ben and Naomi were married.



The seeds of financial collapse were planted early in Ben and Naomi Wister's marriage. When they were married, she was twenty-one and he was twenty-two, and neither one knew much about financial matters. Their plans were simple—they would delay having children for five years. Naomi would use that time to finish